People Like Me

Product case study: discovery, P0, solution, requirements and launch

Bharat

1. Summary

People Like Me matches career switchers with a **Career Guide** who has already made the same move, and a small **pod** of people making it at the same stage. For eight weeks, they meet their Career Guide weekly and their pod twice a week, work towards personal milestones, and set weekly goals the others can see.

The idea came from discovery, not the other way round. Four interviews and 13 survey responses showed that people changing careers don't lack advice; they can't reach anyone who has made their move, so they don't know where to start, lose momentum through weeks of rejection, and give up. The product is live as a web app and has been tested by four early users, whose feedback is shaping the next version. It will not be promoted publicly until a hand-run pilot proves demand.

2. Discovery

Method

Method	How many	Who
Face-to-face interviews	4	People who had left a job, taken a break or were planning a switch; each conversation was summarised afterwards
Survey	13	5 tried to switch careers or roles, 3 took a career break, 5 searched for a job for 3+ months; 10 of 13 had 7 to 12 years of experience

The sample is small, so counts are reported as "x of 13", never as percentages. Nobody in either sample had been laid off.

Survey responses

Question	What people said
Biggest struggle	Staying motivated through silence and rejection (8 of 13); getting referrals and reaching the right people (8); knowing where to start (6); feeling alone (2)
Main channel	Job platforms (11 of 13); own network (8); paid coach, course or cohort (2); WhatsApp or Telegram groups (1)
Reaching out	About once a week (8 of 13)
In a large group or community	Of the 8 who were, 4 mostly read or muted or left; 3 connected one-to-one; 1 took part actively
Support that would have helped	Expert sessions (8 of 13); regular one-to-one with someone who had been through it (6); a small group (5); a large community (4)
Who they wanted but couldn't find	People in their field going through the same thing (8 of 13); someone more senior (7); 12 of 13 named at least one
Spending on support	11 of 13 spent money; 7 spent ₹5,000 to ₹25,000

What the interviews added

All four interviewees could reach plenty of people, but none could reach people in their own situation. One wanted people of her age who had left the same company, to see where they went. Another wanted people at her stage who had landed jobs in Delhi or Gurgaon, and lost her preparation rhythm as her current job took over. A third bought courses and spoke to experts but couldn't follow through. The fourth attended meetups, but the contacts faded.

One survey respondent put it simply: *"maintaining consistency and accountability becomes the challenge especially with other responsibilities."*

Insights

1. **They find many people, but not similar people.** 4 of 4 interviews; 12 of 13 survey respondents.
2. **"Similar" is more specific than a job title.** It means the same starting point, destination and stage.
3. **Momentum and access break, not information.** 11 of 13 struggled most with motivation or referrals.
4. **Switchers don't know where to start; job hunters do.** 6 of 8 switchers, against 0 of 5 long job hunters.
5. **They want someone ahead and peers beside them.** 11 of 13 chose expert sessions or one-to-one with someone who had been through it; 8 of 13 wanted peers going through the same thing.
6. **Large groups don't carry people.** Half of those in large groups went passive.
7. **They already pay for help.** 11 of 13.

Assumptions revisited

Assumption	Verdict	Evidence
People can't find others in their situation	Confirmed	4 of 4 interviews; 12 of 13 survey
Momentum is the hardest part	Confirmed	8 of 13; all four interviewees asked for accountability
Loneliness is the core problem	Not confirmed	Only 2 of 13 felt alone
Layoffs are the main entry point	Not confirmed	0 of 13 and 0 of 4 had been laid off
A group of peers is what people want most	Not confirmed	5 of 13 chose a small group; more wanted someone ahead
Switchers don't know where to start	Discovered	6 of 8 switchers, 0 of 5 job hunters

3. The user

Segment

Career switchers: professionals who have chosen to change direction, switching careers or roles or taking a break to rethink. All four interviewees and 8 of 13 survey respondents sit here. People in a long job search share the motivation problem but not the "where do I start" problem, and laid-off job seekers face a different, urgent search, so both stay out of scope for now.

The other side of the product is the **Career Guide**: an approved, credible person who has made a similar move or has strong expertise in it, and gives a weekly half-hour to someone one step behind.

Persona: Meghna, the stalled switcher

Knows she wants to change direction; can't find anyone who made the same move from where she stands.

Aspect	Detail
Situation	About 8 years in sales at a large company; left a year ago because the environment didn't suit her;

Aspect	Detail
	weighing a move into product
Goals	Know where to start; keep preparing steadily; land a role and environment that fit
Behaviours	Relies on job boards and her own network; reaches out most weeks, rarely to the right people; bought a course and spoke to experts; prepares in bursts, then loses the rhythm
Frustrations	Plenty of people, none in her phase; weeks of no replies wear her down; her network ran dry after a few asks

Meghna is a composite of the four interviews and the survey.

Where the journey breaks

Stage	Friction	Drop-off
Decides to change	Doesn't know where to start	None yet
Looks for people who've done it	Finds plenty of people, none like her	Silent: stops looking
Reaches for alternatives	Courses and groups give direction, not momentum	Unfinished course, muted group
Prepares alone	Job and rejections crowd it out; nobody notices	Silent: preparation fades
Stalls or drifts	Lost confidence	The switch is abandoned

4. The P0

Problems were scored on Population, Intensity and Frequency (1 to 5 each) against one goal: helping career switchers keep making progress until they land.

Problem	P	I	F	Total
They lose motivation through weeks of silence and rejection	4	4	5	13
They can't reach people who made the same move	5	4	3	12
They don't know where to start	4	4	3	11
They struggle to get referrals	4	4	3	11
Large groups they join go quiet	3	3	3	9

On a small sample, 12 and 13 are a tie. Not reaching people who made the same move was chosen as the P0 because it causes the others: with someone who has made the move, a switcher knows where to start, gets referrals and has someone holding them to it.

> **Career switchers can't reach people who have already made the same move. Without them, they don't know where to start, lose motivation through weeks of rejection, and give up before they switch. Every switcher who gives up is a career change that never happens, and a hire that employers and career platforms never make.**

5. From P0 to solution

Root causes

Why	Cause	What would fix it
1	They give up: no starting point, and momentum fades	A clear plan and a steady weekly rhythm
2	Momentum fades because nobody holds them to it	People who see their progress and reach out when they slip

Why	Cause	What would fix it
3	The people they find aren't in their situation, and help is one-off	Someone who made the same move, plus peers at the same stage, over weeks
4	People who made the move have no easy, safe way to help	Warm introductions with a light, clear commitment
5	Platforms know people by job title, not by the move they made	Matching on the move: starting point, destination, stage and constraints

Ideas and prioritisation

Twelve ideas were generated using How Might We, analogies (patient networks, focus partners, cohort courses) and a reverse brainstorm. Each was checked against what already exists, such as LinkedIn search, mentor directories and large cohort groups. Five were shortlisted and scored with RICE (1 to 3 each; score = Reach × Impact × Confidence ÷ Effort).

Idea	R	I	C	E	Score
Career Guide, weekly	3	3	3	2	13.5
Situation pods, twice a week	3	3	2	2	9.0
Occasional expert sessions	3	2	2	2	6.0
Weekly goals tracker on its own	3	1	2	1	6.0
Move-based matching on its own	3	1	2	2	3.0

The chosen solution

The top two ideas combine into a three-layer product:

Layer	What it does	Causes it removes
Foundation: move-based matching	Turns a switcher's own story and CV into a profile of their move, and matches them with a Career Guide and a pod	5
Middle: Career Guide and pod	A 30-minute Career Guide conversation every week, and two pod sessions a week (a 30-minute call and a 15-minute check-in), for eight weeks	2, 3, 4
Top: accountability loop	Two or three weekly goals the Career Guide and pod can see, with a real person reaching out when someone slips	1, 2

Expert sessions join later, for questions several pods share.

6. Product requirements

Goals and non-goals

Goals. Match a switcher with a Career Guide and a pod within days; sustain support every week for eight weeks; make sure a real person notices when someone slips; keep the Career Guide's commitment light.

Non-goals. No WhatsApp or outside group chats; no large communities or feeds; no AI coach or AI-written messages between people; no job board or recruiter access in phase 1; no payments in phase 1; no selling of personal data.

How it works

Step	What the switcher experiences
Sign in and objective	Sign in with Google or email; choose “switch to a new role or field”, “restart after a career break” or “become a Career Guide”
Tell your story	Three short prompts with tap-to-select options and example text, plus a CV; AI drafts a move profile to confirm
Choose a Career Guide	3 to 5 approved Career Guides, each with a reason for the match, a rating (or “New”) and how many people they've guided; “Adjust what matters” refreshes the set; requests expire after 48 hours and the next best match is offered
Join a pod	Four to six people making a similar move at the same stage; each member’s profile can be opened; a “Why this match” panel explains the fit
Plan and week 1	AI drafts four to six milestones; the Career Guide finalises them in the first conversation
Every week	A personal progress dashboard first; plan, calendar and pod one tap away; weekly goals marked done, partly done or not yet

Key user stories

Story	Acceptance criteria (summary)
Tell my story	Three prompts, each skippable and answerable by tapping, typing or speaking; done in under three minutes
Meet my Career Guide	3 to 5 guides with reasons and ratings; contact details hidden until acceptance; automatic rematch after 48 hours
Join my pod	Pods of four to six; member profiles visible only within the pod; “Why this match” summary
Keep the rhythm	Sessions scheduled with calendar invites and video links; rescheduling up to two hours before
Stay accountable	Weekly goals in under two minutes; guide and pod prompted when someone slips; nothing sent automatically on anyone’s behalf
See my progress first	First screen shows week of eight, milestones, goals, sessions attended and the next session
Guide lightly	At most two switchers per Career Guide; decline without a reason; a progress summary before each conversation

Success metrics

Type	Metric	Why
Key	Share of matched switchers who finish eight weeks with at least half their goals met in six or more weeks, still taking search actions in the final two weeks	Momentum carried through the switch is the goal itself
Secondary	Share holding a first Career Guide conversation and pod session within 7 days	Matching and scheduling must work first
Secondary	Share rating their guide and pod 4 or 5 out of 5 on “people like me”	Tests whether matching works
Guardrail	Share of Career Guides who finish their eight weeks and would guide again	Protects guide supply

Risks and open questions

Risk	Early signal	Response
Too few Career Guides for a move	Fewer than three good matches	Start with three common moves; recruit guides by hand before launch
Pods thin out	Fewer than four active	Start at six; reshuffle below three; compare guide-only

Risk	Early signal	Response
	members by week 4	with guide-and-pod
Guides burn out	Missed conversations in weeks 2 to 4	Cap at two switchers; 30-minute calls; quick rematches
Switchers never find it	Sign-ups mostly from people doing fine	Launch where switchers already look

Open questions: what keeps Career Guides engaged over time; whether twice a week is right for pods; how much verification is enough; who eventually pays.

7. What we built, and early feedback

The product is a responsive web app built with React and TypeScript, Supabase, a Node server and the Gemini API, deployed from GitHub to Render. Admin access, used to approve Career Guides and review activity, was added later in the build, so it shows sign-ins from that point onwards; earlier test sign-ins are not captured.

Four people walked through the live app:

Tester	What they told us	What we're changing
Charu	Onboarding felt long, with too many open questions; the flow and journey were smooth	Fewer, merged questions with options and example text
Astha	Couldn't see pod members' profiles; the weekly calendar wasn't clear; too much information at first	Pod member profiles, guiding notes, a simpler interface
Arjun	Landed on the full 8-week plan instead of his own progress	A personal progress dashboard first, with the plan and pod one tap away
Karthik	Couldn't tell why his Career Guide and pod were a match	A "Why this match" panel for the Career Guide and the pod

None of the four questioned the core idea. Their friction was about how much the product asks and shows at once, and every change reduces effort or adds explanation.

8. Launch and go-to-market

Step	What we do	What we measure
1. Pilot (one month)	Hand-pick credible Career Guides and experts; share one registration form across LinkedIn, Reddit, Quora, course cohorts, WhatsApp communities and job platforms; hand-match registrants into small pods; test free against a small fee	Registrations, attendance, goals met, interviews landed, willingness to pay
2. Small launch	Change or pivot the app from the pilot; founder-led LinkedIn stories; alumni networks starting with the founder's colleges; course partnerships; referrals; graduates invited to become Career Guides	Activation, matching within 48 hours, attendance, week-4 retention, outcomes, referrals
3. Scale	New segments one at a time (mothers returning to work, armed forces veterans, people moving back to India, freelancers and founders returning to corporate jobs); paid Career Guide sessions and guided pods; employer partnerships for switchers who opt in	Paying users, retention by segment, hires through partners

The app stays unpromoted until the pilot shows that people sign up, keep showing up, and value it enough to pay.